The Most Fabulous Story Ever Told

By Paul Rudnick

A Christmas Celebration (and unbeknownst to Steve, a wedding). Food has been set out, along with plates, utensils, and napkins. STEVE enters carrying a punch bowl and humming a Christmas song. We hear a key in the front door, and ADAM enters. He is the ebullient Christmas fan and is bursting with excitement.

ADAM: **(Pg 91-92)** Wait, just wait! One second! I saw it, we need it, you'll love it! *(he runs back outside and returns, carrying a nearly life-size plastic reindeer with a bright red nose)*

STEVE: We don't have any more room!

ADAM: But we can't have a party without Rudolph! I was passing by Kmart, and it was the only one left; I had to wrestle it away from this woman with two screaming children! Oh, and I also got. . . *(he runs back outside)*

STEVE: No! You may not bring one more piece of holiday *crap* into this house!

ADAM: *(returns, carrying a large, molded plastic statue of the Virgin Mary)* But this is so special, this is actually sacred . . . *(he places the statue on the table)* It's the Virgin Mary. Only -- she speaks. *(he presses a button at the base of the statue, and a perky recorded voice is heard, coming from inside the statue.*

VIRGIN MARY: Merry Christmas!

ADAM: It's a miracle. A modern miracle.

STEVE: Does she say anything else?

ADAM: I think she got the same tape as Barbie. *(he presses the button again)*

VIRGIN MARY: Math is hard. *(Steve laughs)*

ADAM: **(Pg 93)** *(gesturing to the room)* All of this -- is for you. I want to make every day of your life a Christmas party, from now on.

STEVE: Adam, I don't need parties. . .

ADAM: I do. Because I have something to celebrate -- your life.

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INTRODUCTION

And that's all the Steve knows – it's a party to celebrate Christmas and life. But the party turns out to be much, much more.

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STEVE: **(Pg 93-94)** Okay, how did it go? Tell me. I want to hear it. I mean it.

ADAM: Okay! It was -- incredible. It was, if I do say so myself, the most fantastic, deconstructed, trans-holiday pageant in the history of the elite Preston School first grade. Because I am not just a teacher, oh no. I am a post-modem, multi-cultural genius.

STEVE: "Trans-holiday pageant"?

ADAM: Well, I wanted to be inclusive because it's the right thing to, and because the school is on the Upper West Side and the children's parents are all ultra-liberal. So, I did the entire Nativity, the Wise Men, the shepherds, even the camels, only everyone in it-was gay.

STEVE: You're kidding.

ADAM: The kids *loved* it. The parents *loved* it. This one little boy, who played Jesus, he ran over to his mother, he was just beaming. And he said, "Mommy, I'm gay!" She was *thrilled.* She hugged him and turned to her husband and said, "Darling, this means *Yale!"*

STEVE: But -- the Bible isn't gay.

ADAM: *(triumphantly)* It is now! *(A knock at the door and Adam answers)*

Cheryl enters. CHERYL is a fresh-faced young woman from Utah. She is extremely perky and outgoing, and thrilled to be invited to Adam and Steve's Christmas party (Wedding). As she enters, she is dazzled and awestruck by the loft's Christmas decor.

CHERYL: **(Pg 96)** It's *gorgeous!*

ADAM: *(thrilled)* Isn't it? Steve, this is Cheryl Mindle, my new teaching assistant from school. She just started. Cheryl's not going home for Christmas, so I asked her to come and help with the party.

CHERYL: **(Pg 97-98)** Misty Bluffs. That's where I'm from, in Utah.

STEVE: Are you -- a Mormon? *(whispers)* Are you aware that -- we're gay?

CHERYL: *(totally sympathetic and chipper)* Of course! And I am not judging you, uh-uh! Adam is a

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great guy, and I know that you've been together forever, I mean, way longer than most normal couples. And I know that some good Christians, like my Mom, think that gay people are sick and godless, hut I said, no, Mom, they are sensitive and artistic! *(She gestures with both arms to all the Christmas decor as sincere proof of gay people's artistic glory)*

STEVE: You go, girl! *(CHERYL whoops in agreement and gives a fervently physical, if awkward, two snaps up.)*

CHERYL: Do you know what you need? *Angels.* They're real, and they're everywhere, watching over us. Back home, I have fifteen different hand-painted ceramic angels, three stuffed angels, an angel poster, an angel T-shirt, oh, and two pairs of angel pajamas!

STEVE: Cheryl, are you -- seeing someone?

CHERYL: You mean, like a boyfriend?

STEVE: *(after a beat)* No.

ADAM: Stop itl I bet there are angels in this room, right now! I can feel it! Tonight is gonna be magical!

STEVE: **(Pg 100-101)** Oh no, oh no, I'm having a problem, staying Christmasy.

ADAM: *(to STEVE)* You can do it! For the baby Jesus!

STEVE: But Adam -- you're Jewish!

ADAM: **(Pg 113)** But, I love Christmas, for the decor and the spirit! And I've been changing the Bible. I've been making the stories more gay-positive, and upbeat. *(The doorbell buzzes)*

CHERYL: **(Pg 116-117)** I'll get it.

CHERYL wheels in RABBI SHARON in her wheelchair. SHARON is an aggressively confident, gung-ho woman, a cable TV diva with a mission. She relishes an audience, and a challenge; she's a star.

ADAM: *(going to SHARON, offering his hand)* Hello. Welcome. I'm Adam. And this is Steve.

RABBI SHARON: *(to STEVE, totally upbeat)* The guy with AIDS, am I right? Shalom! *(very excited)* So, does everyone watch my show? Let's hear it! I'm Rabbi Sharon, and welcome to . . .

CHERYL: *(copying SHARON's signature arm gesture, in which she points in a wide, sweeping half-circle, and then points to heaven)* "Who Believes" *(excitedly)* **(Pg 119-121)** Sharon? I believe. And I'm a Mormon!

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RABBI SHARON: No, come on, really?

CHERYL: I am! And I think that God is just the best thing ever!

RABBI SHARON: And Steve. I've heard you're stubborn. You say show me. You say no.

STEVE: You heard right.

RABBI SHARON: Because God did you wrong. AIDS. The homeless. The Holocaust. *(beat)* I still believe, because otherwise I have nothing.

STEVE: You have common sense. You have reality.

RABBI SHARON: Come off it. You think about God more than anyone else in this room.

STEVE: No, I don't!

RABBI SHARON: *(physically pursuing Steve, in her wheelchair; really going after him, picking a fight)* And why not? God made you sick! And not your neighbor, not some fascist dictator, not some creep.

STEVE: It's a virus!

RABBI SHARON: **(Pg 122-124)** And you know something? Sometimes God delivers. Like these new drugs, these cocktails, am I right? Are you on them?

STEVE: Twenty-eight pills a day. -- That is science.

ADAM: That's God! Steve, do you remember our Christmas party last year?

STEVE: We didn't have one.

ADAM: [Because] you'd spent two weeks in the hospital, at 125 pounds, hooked up to a torture chamber, coughing up blood. And I sat in that waiting room, and I cursed God. I said, no more desperate prayers, you get down here, you fix this! *(beat)* All right, Sharon, you're a person of God, right?

RABBI SHARON: With a Web site and a T-shirt!

ADAM: What does it say?

RABBI SHARON: "Oy Gay."

ADAM: So maybe I can ask you-my question. The one I've been trying to get brave enough and strong enough to ask. All right! Here goes. All year long, maybe all my life, things have been-building. To this morning. When I woke up and I looked at Steve, who was curled up, snoring,

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and-smiling. And I looked out the window and it was snowing, just gently, just that perfect MGM snow. And I got my coffee, and I realized that, at exactly that second -- I was. . . happy.

RABBI SHARON: Mazel tov!

ADAM: No! I ducked, I shivered, I was terrified! I thought, no, don't *jinx* it, don't call down a flood or a thunderbolt! And ever since then, I've been in this blind panic. So -- is it okay? To say it, to feel it? To be in love, to have a party, to be -- happy?

RABBI SHARON: You're Jewish, right? *(with genuine compassion, very straightforward)* Sweetheart, I talk to God, all the time. And you know something? God says yes. *(beat)* **(Pg 117-118)** All right, let's get goin'! I've got two basic weddings-with God and without. *(Adam can't contain his excitement. He bounces up and down claps and then goes to Steve and links arms with him; Steve is visibly uncomfortable; but Sharon continues unabashedly)* ***With*** God is non-sectarian but focused on a higher power, with a pronoun of your choice. God can be He, She, Our Mother, Our Father, Our Lavender Light, The Goddess, The Creator, The King, or Our Lord. ***Without*** is more inner, it's the union of souls, the joining of two perfect beings, let our community bless this day, you get the picture . . . . So?

STEVE: (Pg 135) *(to Adam)* Really? *(Steve runs off stage in tears)*

*******Scene – Cheryl and Rabbi Sharon have left and the festive atmosphere is gone ********

ADAM: (Pg 135-137) *(after they are alone)* Steve? *(a long beat)* They've stopped working, haven't they? The pills. The new ones. I noticed, all of your bottles -- they're empty.

STEVE: *(after a beat)* Yup.

ADAM: Were you -- were you going to tell me?

STEVE: Look, they don't work for everyone, and no one's been on them that long, and the side effects are worse than the disease, the whole thing was a crapshoot, I mean, come on.

ADAM: How long have you known?

STEVE: I don't know, a week, what difference does it make?

ADAM: It makes a difference. I said all that bulls***! I said I was happy! I said it was possible! I said that the heavens were smiling down on everyone!

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STEVE: What should I have done? Stood up and said, sorry folks, party's over! Especially for me!

ADAM: Yes! Because that's the truth! And I can handle that!

STEVE: You? And the truth? Adam-you have spent your entire life lunging for answers and miracles and your little kiddie pageant! You have devoted yourself to everything but the truth!

ADAM: But you're the one who's been lying!

STEVE: Fine! You want some facts? Hard-core? *(very simply, straightforward, without histrionics)* I'm dying. And this could very well be our last Christmas together. *(long beat)*

ADAM: *(going to him* Steve . . .

STEVE: No! ***Handle it!***

ADAM: Okay. You're right. You're absolutely right. No more – questions. You are going to die. And I am going to watch you. You win. *(long beat, then sadly)* **(Pg 138-139)** I need . . . a story.

STEVE: Central Park?

ADAM: And the day we met.

STEVE: May third. Ages ago.

ADAM: Lunch time. The first really fabulous day – *(he envisions the park as he walks around the room)* And I thought, I love this park. And I love this city. And I love the air and the breeze and the lake. And I'm alone. And then I turned.

STEVE: *(smiling)* Hey . . . Merry Christmas.

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2010 National Qualifier
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AWARD HISTORY

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